Worship in Spirit and in Truth

True worship is not about the right place but about the right heart and the right God, worship in spirit and in truth, centred on Jesus.

Main passage	John 4:19-26 (KJV)
Topic	Worship
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: Worship is not about the right mountain	7 min
Teaching point 2: Worship in spirit and in truth	7 min
Teaching point 3: True worship centres on Jesus	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "What makes a worship service 'good' to you?" Answers might include the music, the sermon, the building or the people. Then ask: "What makes worship good to God?" This lesson looks at the most important conversation about worship in the Bible, which took place at a well, with a woman who had a complicated past.

Scripture (3 min)

John 4:19-26

[19] The woman saith unto him, Sir, I perceive that thou art a prophet. [20] Our fathers worshipped in this mountain; and ye say, that in Jerusalem is the place where men ought to worship. [21] Jesus saith unto her, Woman, believe me, the hour cometh, when ye shall neither in this mountain, nor yet at Jerusalem, worship the Father. [22] Ye worship ye know not what: we know what we worship: for salvation is of the Jews. [23] But the hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for

the Father seeketh such to worship him. [24] God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth. [25] The woman saith unto him, I know that Messias cometh, which is called Christ: when he is come, he will tell us all things. [26] Jesus saith unto her, I that speak unto thee am he.

Read the passage aloud. If there is time, read John 4:5-18 first so the class knows the setting.

Background (5 min)

Jesus was travelling through Samaria and sat by Jacob's well near the town of Sychar. Jews and Samaritans despised each other. The Samaritans were descendants of Israelites who had intermarried with foreign settlers after the Assyrian conquest. They accepted only the five books of Moses and worshipped on Mount Gerizim, while the Jews worshipped at the temple in Jerusalem.

Jesus had just shown the woman that he knew all about her life (vv. 16-18). When she said, "I perceive that thou art a prophet," she turned the conversation to the oldest religious argument between their peoples: which mountain is the right place to worship?

Teaching point 1: Worship is not about the right mountain (7 min)

The woman raised a question about location, perhaps to change an uncomfortable subject. Jesus took her question seriously, but he moved past it. "The hour cometh" when place would not matter. Arguments about worship can become a way of avoiding God himself.

Supporting verses

John 4:19-21: The woman saith unto him, Sir, I perceive that thou art a prophet. Our fathers worshipped in this mountain; and ye say, that in Jerusalem is the place where men ought to worship. Jesus saith unto her, Woman, believe me, the hour cometh, when ye shall neither in this mountain, nor yet at Jerusalem, worship the Father.

Acts 17:24-25: God that made the world and all things therein, seeing that he is Lord of heaven and earth, dwelleth not in temples made with hands; Neither is worshipped with men’s hands, as though he needed any thing, seeing he giveth to all life, and breath, and all things;

Malachi 1:11: For from the rising of the sun even unto the going down of the same my name shall be great among the Gentiles; and in every place incense shall be offered unto my name, and a pure offering: for my name shall be great among the heathen, saith the LORD of hosts.

> *“She ingeniously shifts the subject”*
>
> — David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on John 4:19-20

> *“Quarrels about religion are usually the most implacable of all quarrels.”*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on John 4:4-26

Handout blanks (answers)

The woman asked whether to worship on the mountain or in **Jerusalem**.

Arguments about worship can be a way of avoiding **God** himself.

Teaching point 2: Worship in spirit and in truth (7 min)

"God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth" (v. 24). Worship "in spirit" comes from the heart and is not merely outward ceremony. Worship "in truth" responds to God as he has really revealed himself. Both are needed: heart without truth becomes emotion, and truth without heart becomes empty form. The Father is seeking such worshippers.

Supporting verses

John 4:22-24: Ye worship ye know not what: we know what we worship: for salvation is of the Jews. But the hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth: for the Father seeketh such to worship him. God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.

Psalm 51:16-17: For thou desirest not sacrifice; else would I give it: thou delightest not in burnt offering. The sacrifices of God are a broken spirit: a broken and a contrite heart, O God, thou wilt not despise.

Romans 12:1: I beseech you therefore, brethren, by the mercies of God, that ye present your bodies a living sacrifice, holy, acceptable unto God, which is your reasonable service.

> *"This is one of the first, the greatest, the most sublime, and necessary truths in the compass of nature!"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on John 4:24

> *"Already there is so much light that God may be worshipped acceptably in any place."*
> — Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on John 4:23

Handout blanks (answers)

God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in **truth**.

The Father **seeketh (seeks)** such to worship him.

Teaching point 3: True worship centres on Jesus (7 min)

The woman said, "I know that Messias cometh." Jesus answered, "I that speak unto thee am he." It is one of the clearest statements of who he is anywhere in the Gospels. True worship is not just a correct method; it is meeting the person of Jesus Christ. The woman went straight back to her town and brought others to him (vv. 28-30).

Supporting verses

John 4:25-26: The woman saith unto him, I know that Messias cometh, which is called Christ: when he is come, he will tell us all things. Jesus saith unto her, I that speak unto thee am he.

John 14:6: Jesus saith unto him, I am the way, the truth, and the life: no man cometh unto the Father, but by me.

Philippians 2:9-11: Wherefore God also hath highly exalted him, and given him a name which is above every name: That at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, of things in heaven, and things in earth, and things under the earth; And that every tongue should confess that Jesus Christ is Lord, to the glory of God the Father.

> *"Our Lord never spoke in such direct terms concerning himself to his own countrymen"*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on John 4:26

Handout blanks (answers)

Jesus said, "I that speak unto thee am **he**."

True worship is meeting the person of **Jesus** Christ.

Teacher note: Christians worship in many styles: liturgical and informal, with hymns or with modern songs. This passage does not settle questions of style; it addresses the heart and the object of worship, which all Christians share.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think the woman brought up the question about the right mountain?

Possibly to move away from her personal life; possibly a sincere question. Either way, Jesus brought the conversation back to God.

2. What does "in spirit" add to worship? What does "in truth" add?

Spirit: heart engagement, sincerity, the work of the Holy Spirit. Truth: worship shaped by who God really is, as revealed in Scripture and in Jesus.

3. What worship arguments do Christians have today, and how might Jesus' words help us?

Style, music, buildings, times. Jesus calls us beyond secondary matters to the heart and to himself.

4. What would it look like for you to worship "in spirit and in truth" this coming Sunday?

Answers will vary: preparing the heart beforehand, attending to the words sung, confession, attentive listening.

Application (3 min)

Before church this Sunday, spend ten minutes preparing your heart: confess sin, read a psalm, and ask God to help you worship in spirit and in truth. During the week, look for ways to worship God at home and work, since worship is not limited to one place.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Father, you are seeking true worshippers. Forgive us when our worship has been only outward, or when we have argued about worship instead of worshipping you. Give us hearts that worship in spirit and in truth. Thank you for revealing yourself in Jesus, the Messiah. May our whole lives be worship to you. Amen.

Sources quoted

David Brown, Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible (Jamieson, Fausset and Brown), on John 4:19-20

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on John 4:4-26

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on John 4:24

Albert Barnes, Notes on the New Testament, on John 4:23

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